THE BURGESS PERSIAN LETTERS

Edited by BENJAMIN SCHWARTZ

PART IV

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, November 20, 1841*

Our Mission was exceedingly well received by the Shah and the Commercial Treaty signed a few days after their arrival, therefore I hope that nothing will occur to cause another quarrel.[57] One of the articles in this treaty is that we are to have two Consuls the one at Tabreez and the other at Tehran; Mr Bonham you know holds the one situation and Mr Abbott the other. If I had been free from my embarrassments on Charles' acct I might perhaps have obtained the latter place. I believe the pay is £350 or £400 a year with liberty to trade. But my present position prevents my trying to get any situation whatever. I still hope however that if I can get clear of Charles I may get some profitable employment in the East. My knowledge of the Persian and Turkish languages, particularly the latter which is known to so few Europeans may some day be of good service to me.

The road between this and Erzeroum is now much disturbed, two English gentlemen coming from Constantinople were robbed near this frontier a short time ago and narrowly escaped being murdered, the spears of the brigands having passed thro' their clothes and slightly wounded them. When the robbers (Koords) found they were English they gave them back the most part of their clothes but took all their money and valuables, and their servants were stripped to their shirts and drawers. Caravans now go a good many together so as to form a large party and there is no more danger to merchandize than formerly. But many single travellers and small parties have been robbed and some people murdered.

Mr Charles Scott (second son of Sir Walter Scott) who was attached to this mission died at Tehran a short time ago, of dysentery, a common complaint in this country although thank God one from which I have never suffered.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, February 3, 1842*

Affairs have taken an odd turn in the east, that is in Afghanistan, since I last wrote to you, poor Sir Alexr Burns[58] the Envoy at Canbul has been murdered along with some officers of his suit. The thing was managed in the following

[57] This treaty now gave British merchants in Persia their first official standing, on a par with Russian and native merchants.

[58] The author of several important works on the Near East.

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manner. Some Afghans of rank, entered his house upon pretence of paying him a friendly visit and when in, killed him, whilst others went to visit and killed in the same way, the officers who were attached to him, and who were living in the town. The rebels then seized some stores and two cannon which were in the town and attacked the palace where the King Shiyah ul Mulh was living but were repulsed. There were some British troops in cantonments outside the town and these on the one side and the king from his fortress the "Balla Hissar" on the other bombarded the town and reduced it to ashes. The 4,000 British troops have since had two actions with the insurgents and have retaken the two guns and a part of the military stores. And they (the British) believe that they have killed about 35,000 of the Afghans but the latter are still reinforced from the mountains where the people are all up in arms. Shiyah ul Mulh has about 1,200 men with him in his palace and some cannon therefore the insurgents are placed between two fires. At Candahar we have an army of 12,000 men but they can not stir to the assistance of the unfortunate 4,000 who are at Canbul until the spring because the mountain passes between Candahar and Canbul are so blocked up with snow that an army can not pass for I should think at least four months,[59] therefore these unfortunate 4,000 men will have to fight against perhaps 100,000 men for at least four months for this affair happened in the month of Novr last. It is said that they are about to augment the army of Afghanistan to 50,000. I am not sorry for this because the expenses will fall upon the company and not upon the British Government, and it will only run the Company a little into debt which all who have money to invest in India are glad of for they get 6–8 and sometimes 10% for their money. An officer of the mission at Tehran has been sent to Khiva[60] to endeavour to put an end to the infamous Traffic in slaves which has been carried on by the turcomans and tartar tribes on the eastern frontiers of Persia for now nearly a century. These tribes being Soonee and the Persians Sheeah (two enimical sects of Mahommedans) the former consider that is perfectly lawful according to their religion to carry off and sell into slavery the latter, the Sheeahs: and the slavery is the worst that exists in the world, they are employed as agricultural laborers ill fed and well beaten. Very unlike the slaves in Persia who are employed as house servants and if they behave well are treated as one of the sons of their master and frequently marry one of his daughters. Persia is much in the same state as it has been for years back, that is as bad as possible. The army and govt servts unpaid, some provinces in open

[59] This proved to be the case; General Pollock was unable to march to the relief of the Canbul garrison until the following spring, by which time the 4,000 men had been massacred.

[60] The officer was Capt. Stoddard, attended by Lieut. Conolly. This begins the famous "Bokhara incident."

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revolt and others close upon it; in fact if it was any other country in the world it could not last, but with Persia all this is nothing; like the eels they are used to it. The British and Russian missions are going on very well together at Tehran and I hope they will continue to do so, their quarreling does no good to any one and is almost certain to do harm to Persia.

I hear that your steam boat fellow traveller the young Earl of Mulgrave has fallen in love with some young lady near St Albans rich, young, handsome and well connected, and that his father would not consent to the marriage, the Earl wanted to run away with the lady but his father has ordered him off to America, to prevent it. I learn this piece of scandal from a most blackguard newspaper called "the Satirist" as it passes thro' my hands on its way to Tehran where it is taken in by one of the members of the mission. I suppose Philadephia is much too proper a place for such a publication to be found in, therefore I give you this piece of news as I thought it might interest you.

I have sometimes thought whether any trade could be carried on between Persia and America. The only things which would be saleable with you and which are exported from this are nut galls and silk, both of these go to London and perhaps may be used in America. I shall in a future letter send you an account of the average price of these articles and what they would cost delivered at Constantinople, and if you want any your employers must apply to Mr Bonham as I could not now execute their orders. Will the jewellers at New York buy turquoises? Persia is the place for them, the only mine in the world is in Persia. These things sometimes leave a large profit in London. The only American product sold here is rum (and sometimes coffee and brown sugar) all these are brought from London, the rum occasionally pays well even when bought at Constantinople and with of course many charges upon it. No doubt these things could be sent much cheaper from Philadelphia to Constantinople than by way of London.

[Edward Burgess to George Burgess] *Tabreez, June 10, 1842*

Mr Bonham started for England on the 27th ult and has left me in charge of his business here, he gives me a salary of 400 Tomauns a year, about £180., this is very handsome and is quite enough to enable me to live very comfortably in this country. I believe I should have been appointed acting Consul during his absence had it not been for my embarrassments, as it is Mr Abbott, Consul at Tehran has come here to take charge of this Consulate. Sir John McNeill, who has gone home was very kind to me when he was here and I have no doubt, would do all in his power for me if I could once get free from my difficulties.

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You have no doubt heard the disastrous intelligence of the massacre of our army at Canbool; the Shah has behaved very well about the affairs of Afghanistan, he has had repeated messages from Herat offering to give up the place to him, to all of which he has refused to listen. If he were to make a movement to the Eastward it would materially increase our difficulties in Afghanistan, by giving encouragement to the Afghans who are opposing us.

The Russians have sent some ships and troops to occupy a small island or islands on the south eastern shore of the Caspian, near Astrabad. The way this has been effected is rather curious and characteristic of the Russian proceedings in the East. You perhaps have heard that for the last century the Turcomans or Tartar tribes who inhabit the great desert to the East of the Caspian have been in the habit of making incursions into Persia and carrying off the inhabitants into slavery and selling them in Khiva, Bokhara and other Tartar states. These inroads were at their height during the latter part of Fatteh Alee Shah's reign, but by this Shah's vigorous measures in Khorasan had been a good deal repressed. Still however they are always going on, chiefly over the frontier from the Caspian Sea towards Herat; and one of their roads was coasting in large boats by Astrabad along the shores of the Caspian to plunder in the province of Mazenderan. Some time ago the Prime minister (the Hadji as he is called) was complaining of these inroads and piracies and said in the course of conversation with one of the attachés of the Russian Mission that he wished that there were some Russian forces there to stop them. No more was said upon the subject until some months afterwards when one of the Russian Mission came to the Hadji and said "I have brought you good news" "What is it?" said the Hadji. "Our army has arrived off Astrabad." The Hadji was quite taken aback and had very little to say for himself. The Russians now demand, permanently to occupy one of the islands in these seas, as they say to repress the piracies which have been committed by the Turcoman boats on their ships, which trade to the coasts of Mazenderan (pt of anct Hyrcania). If the Russians succeed in forming a military settlement here, I shall think it most probable that we shall deem ourselves obliged to retake and maintain Herat. This will bring us, to within about thirty marches of one another. And a practicable road for armies between us.

By Mr Bonham, I sent home, to be delivered to my Mother, to send to you, a silver handled dagger or rather knife. It formerly belonged to the Governor of the town and you may think it curious as shewing the sort of thing Persians of rank wear stuck on their shawl girdles: It did not cost me much I think I paid the value of 25/ for it, so do not suppose I am sending you an expensive present. I have had it by me some time but had no good opportunity of sending it. It is not likely to be of much use to you unless some of your neighbours

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attempt to gouge you, and then if you use it to some purpose as I hope you will I shall say of you as the Turks do when they hear of any of their friends having stabbed a man and they approve of it "may his hand never ache."

You will no doubt wonder at my writing such a large straggling hand the reason of it is this. When Mr Bonham was here I had to copy a great many of his despatches. And one of the rules at the Foreign Office is that everything must be written in a large plain legible hand, which my handwriting most certainly was not. I am therefore endeavouring to get the habit of writing the sort of hand that is approved of. Even this hand would not be remarked but my former hand writing was such as would not pass. — I hope you will not have to pay postage on this, please let me know as if you have, I must write small again. It never occurred to me until this instant that in England a triple letter carried two hundred miles used to cost four or five shillings. I shall be very sorry if you have to pay this sum for this, but I hope that in America they have some thing like the Whigs penny postage system. And I believe my friends the Missionaries will send this to America for me free of expense at least they ought to do so, because our couriers carry their letters and even books and tracts, for nothing. Last winter when Mr Bonham was at Tehran and I was charged with the forwarding the Govt Messengers, I have packed up many a packet of theirs in Her Majestys despatch bags. —

I do not know whether you take any interest in the politics of these countries if you do not my letters must be uninteresting, but I hope you do, and I take great interest in the affairs of the U: S: altho I can not say that I am a great admirer of the people; perhaps I may be prejudiced against them. If you will engage to read every book you can find regarding Persia I will do the same with regard to the U: S: and I hope you have access to good maps. But perhaps you may have little time to look at books or maps either. I had none when I was at Kelsall's and if I had looked at a book or a map when I was at Cleggs I should have been mobbed by the whole family. I mention these things because two men to take interest in each others conversation or letters must be acquainted with some common subject of interest. Perhaps the most entertaining man I ever met, was a Hungarian doctor who was here for some years. He was a great linguist and spoke Turkish with great correctness ease and fluency. A Persian speaking of him the other day said "that was a man who if you were to live with him ten years would never tell you the same anecdote twice." He was a great miser and not a man of amiable disposition; but from his great information he was a most agreeable companion. — The Persians are frequently most agreeable companions full of fun and wit. The Hadji (Prime minister) is celebrated for abusing people and sometimes his abuse altho very gross is witty. The following

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is perhaps the best. You must know that near Tehran there is a very high mountain the summit of which is clad with eternal snow. Meerza Aga Khan the minister of war is a very clever man and the Hadji knowing him to be so, loses no opportunity of giving him a rap on the knuckles so as to keep him down, and prevent his interfering with him; for in no country in the world has sarcasm, wit and ridicule, such power as it has in Persia. Some time ago when Meerza Aga Khan presented himself early in the morning at the Hadji's levée, the Hadji turned towards him suddenly and said "Meerza Aga Khan are you aware that the devil attended by a large retinue sits every morning before sunrise on the peak of Demawund?" (the mountain before mentioned). "No," said the man expecting something disagreeable. "Yes he does," said the Hadji, "and as the sun begins to rise he sends some of his people into the town to bring him intelligence of what Meerza Aga Khan is about, and when they return and report to their master that Meerza Aga Khan is up, and has put on his shoes, and is on his way to the court he says come along boys, we need not trouble ourselves about Tehran any more to day, Meerza Aga Khan will make quite mischief enough there without our assistance!" Not bad was it?

Are we to have war about "the Creole?"[61] bravo the blackees, say I. I think you will own that your friends have got hold of the wrong pig by the ear in this question. I have only seen the London papers up to the 15th April. Please when you write let me know something about the Canadian frontier that is if you hear any thing about the "sympathizers."[62]

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, August 1, 1843*

We do not yet know whether we are to have war or peace with Turkey. About a month ago the Shah wrote to his brother the governor here, ordering him to hold himself in such a state of readiness, that if in the morning he received orders from him, to take the field with twenty thousand men he could march out of Tabreez before the evening: this looked like war; and the Shah himself had moved out of Tehran and ordered warlike preparations to be made all along the frontier. But since then I believe the mediators England and Russia have obliged

[61] On Oct. 27, 1841, the *Creole*, a brig from Richmond, Virginia, sailed from Hampton Roads for New Orleans with a cargo of slaves and tobacco. During the voyage some of the slaves revolted and killed the slave dealer, then forced the crew to put in at Nassau. There the British authorities freed the slaves, after holding nineteen on charges of murder and mutiny. Southern politicians waxed furious over the incident but saner counsels prevailed and eventually the case was arbitrated and the United States awarded monetary damages for interference with the cargo of the ship.

[62] These were American sympathizers of a Canadian separatist movement, cf. footnote 53, on the McLeod affair.

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the Turks to be more reasonable, but there is no telling whether we shall have a fight or not yet.[63] The Turks began the negociations by demanding that the Persians should give back to them or make good, the cannon and other warlike stores which they lost at the battle of Topreh Kaleh, where the Persians beat them, in, I think, the year 1823, and after which they made peace[64] which peace has never been broken until within the last twelve month, if the skirmishes on the frontier can be called, breaking the peace between the two countries. In case of a war we should have manufactures (Manchester) up forty or fifty per ct almost immediately, because the roads being impassable the supply would be stopped from this end, but it would be a long time ere we could get supplied from the other viz: Bombay, Benderi, Busheer and Meeraz, and even when they did come the extra land carriage would make them very dear. Some of these goods have lately been brought to Tehran from Baghdad, but I doubt whether this line will answer to any extent yet. The traffic on the river between that town and Bussora is so dangerous and uncertain on account of the disturbed state of the Arab tribes on its banks. If the navigation of the river was unimpeded the importers by way of Bussora and Baghdad would certainly be able to undersell at Tehran those by way of Busheer and Meeraz and perhaps even those of this northern route viz. Constantinople, Trebizonde and Erzeroom: because they would save a great deal in land carriage. This line of trade is yet in its infancy and I doubt much whether it will succeed on account of the reason above stated and because the Persian Baghdad frontier is always disturbed and from the nature of the inhabitants always likely to be so.

Mr Bonham was to have been married in July and we expect him here with his wife in October, Mr Abbott then goes to Tehran. We do not know who is to be ambassador here, Mr Ellis is talked of, would that Charles had not quarreled with him. Col Shiel is now acting as Chargé d'Affaires and has been since Sir John McNeill's departure, but he does not expect to be confirmed, because his brother is on the wrong side in politics and moreover the said Colonel has saved a good deal of money, is in bad health, and wants to get home. I continue to translate the newspapers for the Prince for which I get nothing as yet but it may lead to something. He gave me a Cashmeer shawl worth nine or ten pounds.

[63] After a series of increasingly serious border incidents in 1842, Persian religious opinion was outraged by an attack on Kerbela and a massacre of its inhabitants. Although this city was on Turkish soil, it had long been considered a Shi'a shrine, and there was a popular demand for war with Turkey. Extensive military preparations were made, but England and Russia intervened in the role of mediators, especially for the purpose of delimiting the Turco-Persian border. Curiously, this joint mediation board continued on and off until 1914(!), when the border was finally officially defined.

[64] The treaty of Erzerum concluded the hostilities of 1821–1823. The battle of Topreh Kaleh, the final battle of that war, was won by the Persians against greatly superior numbers.

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[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, January 9, 1844*

I do not think that I ever told you that the Prince has made me chief magistrate of two villages containing about a thousand inhabitants. I did not mention it to my Mother because I wished to see whether it brought me in anything or not, but now notwithstanding my having made nothing by this business, except a three year old colt, seven sheep and a few baskets of raisins, as I think a few anecdotes of my judgements may amuse you I mention it.

These villages belong to the late Dr Cormicks children and as I was frequently unable to get in their rents I asked the Prince to make me chief of them, which he did. I have to collect the taxes from the village and pay them into the treasury. This is all easy enough but what gives me work is this: according to the customs of the country all these villagers look to me for protection, if they are robbed they come to me to catch the thief, if they are in any way oppressed they come to me to plead their cause before the Prince and see that they have justice done them; to such an extent is this carried that last autumn when I was at the village one day as I was walking along the street a man came to me and said "salaam aleikum" "Peace be unto you" making a low bow. "Well," said I, "what now?" "What now?" said he, "why they have plundered the village, harried it and driven everything away." I knew that this was a figurative way of saying that he had been robbed so I asked him what he had lost he said; "I beg to represent that some months ago I had a most beautiful kettle and it was stolen; as you are the chief of this village it is your duty to listen to our complaints, redress our grievances and find my kettle for me." I did my best to find his kettle but unfortunately without success and not many days ago he came to Tabreez and again bothered me about his kettle! It is true he and his brother had other business which was this; they had cultivated a piece of land near the shores of the lake at immense labour and the chief of the village had taken it from them and given it to some of his own relations. (In Persia there are usually two chiefs to each village the one chosen by the villagers the other appointed by the Govt, the Govt one has the supreme command the other is one of themselves). I gave him an order to have his land again and he went away rejoicing and thinking less about his kettle. There are several men of great respectability and considerable property for Persia, in one of these villages. I was breakfasting with one of them, when I was at the village and he said "would that you had been chief of this village two years ago." I said "Why?"

"Because," said he, "you could have saved me two hundred pounds. I have never myself had any business with you but I hear from others who have, that you spare no pains to see justice done to them. When they come to Tabreez

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with complaints, away you go to the Prince, and you speak up, you speak manfully and you speak well, and you would fight with any nobleman in the land rather than not see your people get justice. I had a piece of land near Beenaub (a town adjoining the village), it had belonged to my fathers before me. Two years ago a rascal got false witnesses, made out false title deeds, got a decision from the cazi (judge) and took my land from me; I upset the decision but could not get possession; and after the most vexatious lawsuits I was obliged to rebuy my own land, if you had had the village you would have gone at once to the Prince and obtained me justice." I should also tell you to enable you to understand all this that in the east there are two sorts of law, the one the written Mahommedan law, as interpreted by the cazi and the Mollahs (priests) and the other the decisions of the govt officers which ought to be equity. The govt is in almost all cases the executive and puts in force the decisions of the cazi; *when it pleases*. But these same cazis and Mollahs have become such an infernal set of scamps that people have as little to do with them as possible. I often to save myself trouble told the villagers to go to the cazi but they wont go. You may imagine the trouble I have with them from the affair of the kettle, and to which I must tell you that the inhabitants of these two villages are perhaps as unruly and troublesome a set as any in Persia, they are much such fellows as we had on the borders of Scotland two hundred years ago, most of them armed, many of them robbers on the high way, and the greater part of them wine drinkers. I have had but one case of robbing on the high way since I had the village. There were two of them engaged in the robbery (of a Turk Mousul). I found out from the other villagers who they were and sent an order to the village to have them caught, their feet fastened in blocks of wood to prevent their running away and brought in that state to Tabreez. The man whose servant they had robbed begged them off or I should have given them a much severer punishment than they had, as it was they had about one hundred blows each on the soles of the feet, and as they see I am not to be trifled with I hope they will leave off their mal practices. But they have been within the last few days getting drunk and fighting amongst themselves and as I was sitting down to write this letter three of them came in to complain; several of them have been wounded with daggers, one badly; I must punish some of them or we shall have no peace, not that I care much about their fighting but if the Prince hears that I keep such bad order in my villages he will give me no more or perhaps take these from me. I do not dispair because I have made nothing out of these villages this year, it was an entirely new trade to me, and I have had much to learn, besides the sheep, fruit, etc., which the villagers bring to their chief to repay him for his trouble he ought to get 20% on the revenues (taxes) of the village. And then this village has been

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shamefully oppressed by Houssein Khan's people. It formerly belonged to Houssein Khan, ambassador to England.[65]

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, April 6, 1844*

Perhaps you may have seen in the English papers something about the doings of a certain chief called Shahmeel, this man is the chief or king for he now calls himself Shahmeel Shah of a tribe of people called Lezgies who inhabit the mountains which have been called the eastern spur of the Caucasus.[66] They are Mahomedans of the Soonee[67] sect but they are by far the most liberal of any of the four divisions of that sect. Altho the whole of Georgia has been overrun by the Russians these people and the Circassians have never been conquered. And the Russians have had almost constant hostilities with them. Latterly this Shahmeel has come into power and has put some order amongst them and last year his armies beat the Russians in several battles. Georgia is one of the penal settlements of Russia and many of the troops who are there are sent there as a punishment, no troops in the world are so miserably fed, paid and clothed as the Russians, and before the Persians sent back Russian deserters they had always two battalions of these men in the service. Now instead of deserting to Persia they desert to Shahmeel and he has several regiments of these men in his service; they are in great measure composed of Poles and other foreigners but many are true Russians. These men are well paid clothed and fed and of course they fight well because they fight with ropes about their necks. In fact such power has this Shahmeel Shah now obtained that it is said this year the Russians intend to send an expedition of above one hundred thousand men against him (some say 200,000), but I should think they would not be able to send even the first named number; a little assistance now from Persia or perhaps even from Turkey might drive the Russians once more over the Caucasus.

You may recollect that last autumn I gave you an account of the slaughter of the Armenian (American I read it by mistake) by the Turks of Constantinople, you will perhaps have seen from the papers ere this reaches you that the British and French Ambassadors are endeavouring to force the Turkish government

[65] Hussein Khan was Mohammed Shah's special envoy to England in 1839, during the Shah's vain attempt to have the British ambassador, Sir John McNeill, recalled. The Persian had to make so many concessions to Lord Palmerston, without attaining the object of his mission, that on his return to Persia he "ate many sticks," i.e., was severely bastinadoed.

[66] For an account of the career of Shāmil, cf. *Encyclopaedia of Islam,* vol. 4, pt. 1, p. 306–7, and bibliography. See also footnote 38.

[67] The two chief sects of Islam are the Sunni and Shi'a. The Persians are of the latter sect, the Turks the former. For an account of the essential differences between the two, cf. e.g., Encyclopaedia of Islam, vol. 4, pt. 1, p. 350–58, with bibliography.

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to abolish the barbarous law by which any one who changes from the Christian or any other religion to the Mahomedan and then back again is considered worthy of death. The whole body of the priesthood (Ulema) of Turkey are against granting the demands of the Ambassadors but the latter it is said threaten to break off all friendly relations with the Porte if their demands are not complied with.[68] The Persians even add that a steamer was at Constantinople ready to take them away if they did not receive a favorable answer on a certain day, but as the Persians are anxious to see the Turks heads broken no matter by whom, this last piece of news is not to be depended upon.

Mr Bonham wanted to establish a post between this and Erzeroom. There is already one between that and Constantinople and from thence all over the world, but the thing did not go on. He wanted Col Sheil now our Chargé d'affaires at Tehran, to allow him the sum which he (the Col.) gets from the Govt for sending couriers once a month and Mr B. engaged to despatch his post once a week. But the Col would not agree. It would have been no great benefit to me personally, for had the post been established we should all have had to pay for our letters and as it is we receive them gratis by the Govt couriers. The Greek merchants established here have foot posts once a week who come from Erzeroom when the roads are not blocked up with snow in ten or twelve days. The distance is about 370 miles. This is not bad walking when you consider that they carry large bundles of letters and newspapers. These Greek merchants are with one or two exceptions a most outlandish set, the Persians are a much more intelligent set of men than they are, that is the gentry. Yet these fellows call themselves Europeans and have the insolence to call the Persians barbarians; in Europe also the Persians are called barbarous I think without justice. A people who have Euclid and Algebra surely can not be called barbarous and these the Persians have. Not having learnt them from the Europeans but from the Arabs. You perhaps may not be aware that this last science is of Arabic origin and still with us bears the same name *ul jebr*.[69] The last word "jebr" or "gebr" meaning cruelty oppression injustice "ul" the article and it received this name from the "cruelty" or the "injustice" of making a poor fellow split his brain with learning a thing so difficult. But to return to the Greeks, of whom there are some ten or fifteen in Tabreez now, except about their trade they have not two ideas in their heads. All day long they are employed at their warehouses either transacting

[68] The Porte did bow to the demands of the European ambassadors and the law was abolished, a fact which did not prevent similar massacres right up until World War I.

[69] *al jabr* is literally "setting a bone" i.e., "reducing it from a fractured state," cf. E. W. Lane, Arabic-English Lexicon, London, 1865, Bk. I, pt. 2, p. 373–74. Applied to computation *al jabr* means "the resolution (i.e., addition, subtraction, etc.) of fractions and whole numbers," hence *algebra*, which came into the western languages in this form through Late Latin.

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their business or smoking chatting and drinking coffee and at night they meet at each others houses to play at whist and other games at cards, and they play high too, like all the Christians of Constantinople. They dress in an odd fashion which is called European here, they wear great coats of cloth buttoned up to the chin or sometimes fur pelises which look much better, Persian caps and loose Cossack trousers and almost all wear their beards.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, May 7, 1844*

I received your most kind and affectionate letter on the 27th ulto It is dated New York 26th Feby therefore it has come very quickly. In answer to your questions, I am sorry to say that I cannot accept your kind offer, because I cannot leave Persia without coming to some arrangement with my creditors, that is without running away, which you know I would never do. I believe that now my destiny is fixed for Persia, that is I do not at all dispair of being able to get to England for a time if I could come to some arrangement with my creditors, but from my knowledge of the Persian and Turkish languages and my knowledge of Asiatic affairs it is most likely that my occupations whatever they may be, will be in some way or other connected with the East. My salary with Mr Bonham was Ts 400. a year, about £180. But he has left off trading and my agreement with him was up on the 21st March, last. And I am now no longer in his service. I mentioned this to the Prince governor, and he has agreed to give me the same pay, so I am now in his service. My work is translating the newspapers, and other things. But the Prince has ordered me not to mention that I am in his service, as the Prime minister, who is his enemy, might make it a pretence for troubling him. Therefore please do not mention this in any way so that it might come back to Persia. The answer I shall give to any one who asks me is that the Prince gives me something for my translations. And this year I hope to make something out of the two villages of which I am governor. If the Prince Bahman Meerza was not afraid of the Prime minister, he would I am pretty sure put me into some place which would give me an opportunity of earning something towards paying my debts, indeed he has promised to advance me as soon as ever an occasion occurs, but he is obliged to be cautious as a word from the minister would force him to deprive me of my place. There are several villages in the district of Ouroumia[70] inhabited by Nestorian Christians; these people are much oppressed by their chiefs, and they, seeing that I governed the two villages which are under my charge (the inhabitants of which are all Mahomedans) with justice, and much to the advantage of the villagers, sent some

[70] Cf. Justin Perkins, passim, op. cit.

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of the principal men in the villages to me to request me to endeavour to get them placed under my charge; also this for certain reasons I did not then do. But I think of trying to get it for next year, and if I succeed it will bring me in a most hansome revenue, I should think to begin with, not less than £1000. one thousand pounds. The deputies from the villages offered to give me their bond for five hundred, if I could get the matter arranged. This money accrues from 10 pr cent on the Govt taxes which is paid by the villagers to their chief to remunerate him for his trouble in protecting them, and other fees, fines etc. which he gets from them. And this amount might be doubled or perhaps trebled by good government and kind treatment. The American missionaries have urged me strongly to undertake this matter; and they say that by doing so I shall deserve the blessings of all Christendom for protecting a number of suffering Christians from the oppression and tyranny of their Mahomedan chiefs. It will be a most difficult business to manage as these villages are now in the hands of the nobles of Afshar (Nadir Shah's tribe) who are perhaps the most turbulent, proud and unruly of all the nobles of Persia. These men would, to a man, oppose me and with reason for from a village which in the Govt books is rated at say Ts. 300. pr annm, they take six. Half they account to the Govt for and half is their own profit.

[EDWARD BURGESS TO MRS. HENRY BURGESS] *Tabreez, June 6, 1844*

On the 13th ulto I received yours of the 23 March. I am very sorry to hear of the death of Mr. and Mrs. Webbe. You my dear Mother must have felt the death of the latter acutely. She was almost the only person I recollect with whom you were on terms of intimacy and friendship. In mentioning your having heard Mozarts requiem you write "do not think I am grown superstitious." If you knew *how* superstitious your son was, you would not think it necessary to write that sentence. It is rather curious that your letter should have arrived a few days after I had written mine (9th May) about the jins.— I have just received a long letter from uncle and aunt E. Smith, the latter's letter is full of "Said" and unfortunately in answering it I quite forgot to mention any thing about him, which is an omission I am sorry for. I would have congratulated them upon their adopted son, when one can please people by paying them a few empty compliments I usually make it a rule to do so, particularly people who have been so kind to me as they have. Can you tell me what breed Mr Said is of. In Egypt Arabia and Persia there are three kinds of slaves well known to commerce; the first is the Abyssinian which are worth from all prices 25 to 500 £ or even more, the next the Nubian who are not so good, and the last the thorough bred negro who are dear at 6 or 7 £, their average price here. I am afraid they have been cheated so please tell me what breed Mr Said is.

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On Monday the 13th May we had a sharp shock of an earthquake and we have since learnt that this was felt more severely at Kashan and Meeanna. In the district of Meeanna a town about 100 Miles S. E. of this, many villages were completely thrown down and the town itself half ruined. Numbers of people have been killed and wounded. At Ispahan the great mosque is injured. It is very seldom that earthquakes spread over such an extent of country as this has done. Tabreez appears to have been the extremity on one side and Ispahan on the other. I believe this is the first time Ispahan has been visited by these calamities which may account for its being almost the only decent looking city in Persia. Who in his senses would build a house two or three stories high with the chance of having it come tumbling about his ears as soon as it was finnished.

I dont know whether I ever told you a story of H. R. H. Mallic Cossim Meerza; this man is one of the sons of the late king[71] and is remarkable for his European predilections. He talks French fluently, English pretty well, and Russian a little and he has learnt a little of Geography and Astronomy. He wears European clothes and drinks wine etc. He was lately appointed governor of the town and district of Booroojeerd in the center of Persia, where they have seen very little of Europeans. Soon after his arrival the oolooma (body of the priesthood) waited upon him and preached to him about the sin and scandal of his having adopted the manners and dress of the infidels. The first day he was very civil and gave them evasive answers, the next he remonstrated using the usual arguments of loose fishes in Persia, that his going to a certain hot place would not oblige them to come too, that every one has a right to do as he pleased etc. At last after some days he said "gentlemen have you seen *my* priests, *my* oolooma?" "No," said they, "we have seen nothing like a Mollah about your establishment." "Boys," said he calling to his servants, "open the doors." They did so and H. R. H. gave a long loud whistle, when in rushed greyhounds, Spaniels, pointers, large dogs used for fighting wolves and wild boars, and curs of almost every description. The Mollahs tucked up their robes and began hopping about to avoid being contaminated by touching the dogs and went away spitting right and left and cursing the Prince in the most classic Arabic — They never troubled him again.

(To be continued)

[71] Fath Ali Shah.

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